



crowns as skipper (seven overall). However, on March 17, even the most ardent RCB fan couldn't help but feel for the decorated Australian. Yet another thing no one saw coming.

However, there was one change that everyone in the ecosystem predicted. While the first edition needed to be thrust up by performances from proven international pros, season two saw the Indian talent pool tap the overseas contingent on the shoulder and say, "We've got this. Take some rest."

Indian dividends

Asha Sobhana Joy, true to her name, brought hope and happiness to RCB with a five-wicket haul early in the tournament, where she proved unplayable against UP Warriorz. She emerged as a vital cog in the RCB spin wheel alongside Shreyanka Patil, Sophie Molineux, and Georgia Wareham.

Shreyanka surpassed last year's impressive performances by winning the Purple Cap, despite a slow start to the season and a hairline fracture in

her non-bowling arm.

Sixteen-year-old Shabnam Shakil made her debut for the Gujarat Giants, becoming the youngest player in the league. Her talent was recognised by Charlotte Edwards, coach of the Mumbai Indians, who believed she would only improve with time.

UP Warriorz's pacer Saima Thakor didn't accumulate as many wickets as she would have liked, but her spirited dismissal of Shafali Verma won her a fan in teammate Grace Harris. "I loved that fiery nature. If you want to last in international cricket, you need to have that in your belly and be able to take down the best. When Shafali Verma is walking down to you, you must be able to say, 'Alright, get back in your crease!'"

Before the start of the season, Giants' vice-captain Sneha Rana told this publication that it's time people stopped making age a barometer for cricket. The entire edition and the players in it worked overtime to uphold her words. Mumbai Indians' pacer Shabnim Ismail, 35, bowled the fastest recorded delivery in women's

Crowning moment: Royal Challengers Bangalore claimed its first Women's Premier League title with an eight-wicket victory over Delhi Capitals in the final in Delhi. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

cricket — a 132.1 kmph ripper, sent darting at none other than Lanning. Asha is 33 and made heads turn, hoping to find more opportunities. Another MI star, all-rounder Sajeewan Sajana, is 29. After that last-ball six in the tournament opener, which turned the spotlight on her and her story, she hopes to make her way to an India cap. Gouher Sultana (UP Warriorz) and Ekta Bisht (Royal Challengers Bangalore) are 35 and 38, respectively, while Harmanpreet Kaur rang in her 35th birthday a day later with an unbeaten 48-ball 95 against the Giants.

Old chinks return to haunt India

This edition provided key insights for the Indian national team: Deepti Sharma showcased power-hitting prowess, earning the MVP award with 295 runs and 10 wickets, while Jemimah Rodrigues improved